

THE BIRTH OF RITUAL

prehistoric magic



▲ Carnac stones

Stretching out for more than a mile in Brittany, northwest France, are more than 3,000 stones, erected around 6,000 years ago, which are thought to have had some religious significance. Many of them are aligned in such straight rows that medieval local people believed they were a Roman army magically turned to stone.

As early as 95,000 years ago Neanderthals (a hominin species related to modern humans) carefully buried a small child in a cave in Iraq with a reverence that suggests belief in an afterlife. The leaving of pebbles that look anthropomorphic (with human characteristics) in caves, and the building, around 2500 BCE, of stone circles—such as Stonehenge and Carnac—that were aligned to the sun's rising or setting at certain times of year, point to an increasingly sophisticated and religious world view. With religion came magic.

► The Jericho skull

This skull from around 7500 BCE was found in Jericho in the Jordan valley. It was partially covered in plaster and the eye sockets filled with shells to recreate the deceased's features, possibly as part of an ancestor cult.



► Animal rites

The cave paintings at Lascaux in southwestern France date from around 15,000 BCE. Nearly 900 animals were depicted in all, most likely as part of a magic hunting ritual.

Prehistoric magic and early religion

Early people learned to control the environment by inventing tools and using fire. These skills gave them limited power but at the same time made them aware of just how vast the forces were that were out of humankind's control. To understand such mysteries as the sun's rising and setting, birth and death, and the daily struggle to hunt for food for survival, our earliest ancestors conceived of spirit forces that they could invoke to gain an advantage. A belief in supernatural forces and a human desire to use them to gain some sway over the physical world has been a feature of societies ever since.

Power and survival

Hunting was essential for the survival of early human communities. Societies that have relied on tracking and killing animals into modern times, such as the Inuit of Arctic Canada, view hunting as a sacred act as it takes the life of another being that they believe possesses a soul. Stone Age peoples may have thought similarly. From around 17,000 years ago they adorned barely accessible caves, such as Lascaux in France, with paintings of people hunting wild animals including stags, horses, bison, cattle, and bears. These paintings may have been connected with rituals to make hunting expeditions more successful or have been intended to appease the animals' spirits.

“Mourning the dead was one of the shared rituals that helped bind the society together.”

BRITISH MUSEUM, ON THE JERICHO SKULL